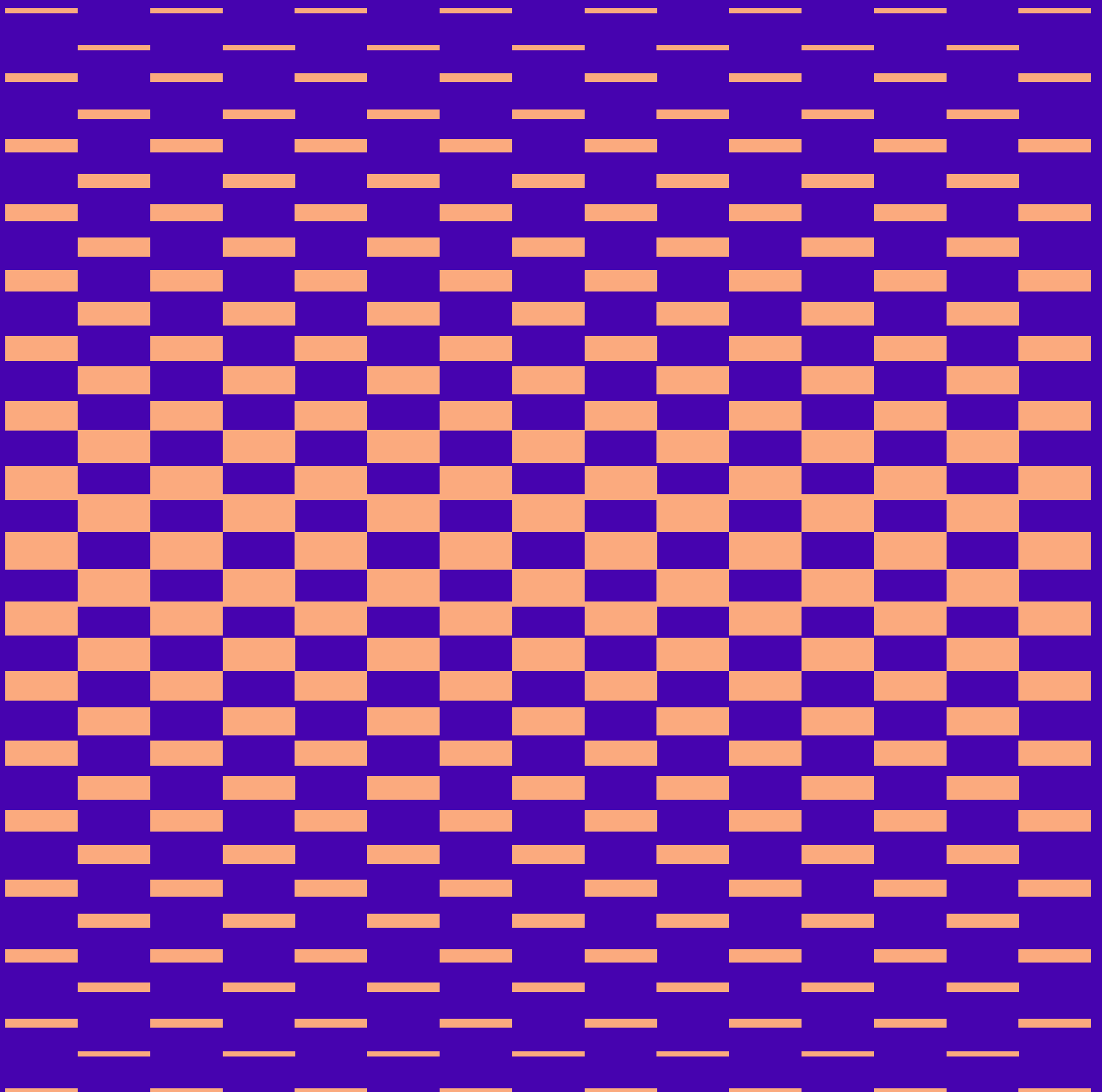




Is My Website Accessible?

A Practical Guide for Business Owners



What is Website Accessibility?

Website accessibility means ensuring that anyone, regardless of disability or impairment, can access, navigate and interact with your site. It covers a wide spectrum of needs, including visual, auditory, motor and cognitive differences.

This guide will walk you through how to check your website for accessibility issues and make practical improvements, even if you're not a technical expert.

We will find out:

01 How to check for usability issues

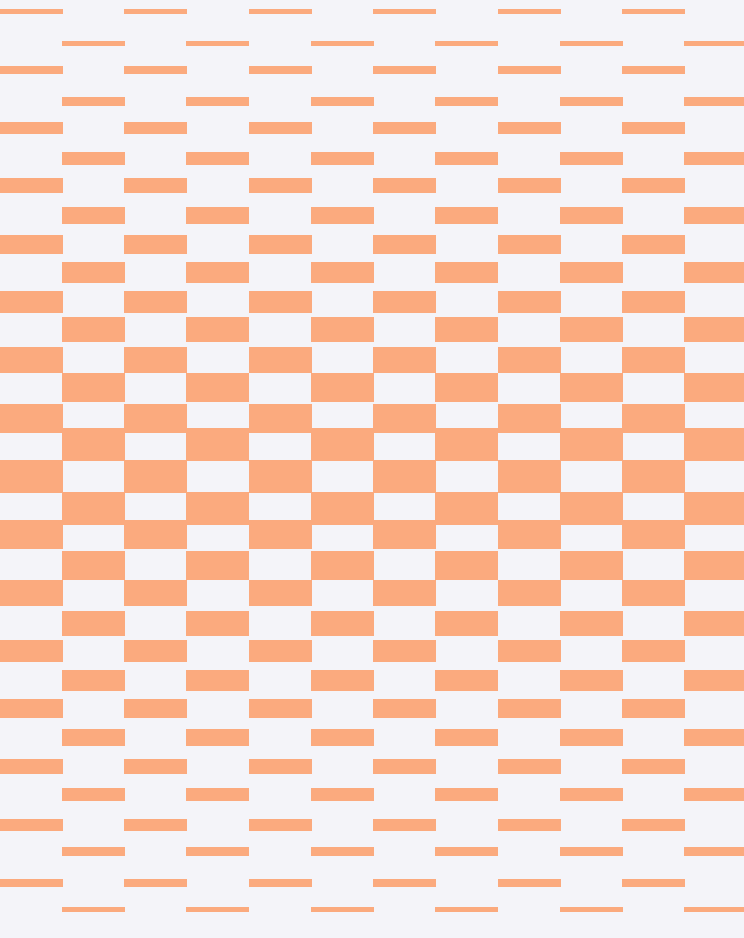
02 Reducing text & readability issues

03 Are your images & media accessible?

04 Assessing your links & buttons

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06 Checking your site's structure & code



How to check for usability issues

Usability is the foundation of accessibility. If people cannot find what they need or complete key tasks, technical compliance will not save the experience. Start with a short usability sweep before deeper checks.

Navigation and wayfinding

- Menus should be predictable and consistent across pages. Test both mouse and keyboard. Can you open and move through a dropdown with the arrow keys and Enter key?
- Provide a clear route to key pages such as Services, Pricing, Contact, and Support. Add a visible focus style so keyboard users can see where they are.
- Add breadcrumbs on deeper pages to aid orientation.

Layout and visual hierarchy

- Use a clear visual hierarchy for headings, subheadings, and body text. Limit competing elements in the hero area. Keep primary calls to action above the fold without crowding the page.
- Check spacing. Adequate white space reduces cognitive load and helps people scan.

Responsiveness and device testing

- Test on a small phone, a large phone, a tablet, and a laptop. Rotate between portrait and landscape. Content should reflow without hiding controls or overlapping text.
- Use the browser's device toolbar to preview common sizes. Validate that mobile menus are easy to tap and dismiss.

Testing tools:

- [Google Lighthouse](#) highlights usability issues
- [BrowserStack](#) lets you test your site on different devices and browsers
- Ask someone unfamiliar with your site to find key information — their feedback can reveal hidden usability barriers

A site that is straightforward and intuitive is the foundation of accessibility. Fixing usability problems will make the rest of your accessibility work far more effective.

Reducing text & readability issues

Readable content is essential for people with low vision, dyslexia, and cognitive differences. It also improves comprehension for every visitor who is in a hurry.

Typography and sizing

- Use a base size of at least 16px for body text. Increase line height to around 1.5 to support scanning. Provide generous paragraph spacing.
- Choose a clear sans serif for body copy. Reserve decorative fonts for short headings only.

Colour and contrast

- Aim for a minimum contrast ratio of 4.5 to 1 for body text and 3 to 1 for large headings. Check text on buttons, over images, and on coloured panels.
- Avoid presenting information through colour alone. Pair colour with text or icons so meaning is retained.

Plain language and structure

- Prefer short sentences and familiar words. Replace jargon with everyday language. Define unavoidable terms the first time you use them.
- Break content into sections with descriptive headings. Use ordered or unordered lists for steps and features. Keep paragraphs short to reduce cognitive effort.

Testing tools:

- [WebAIM Contrast Checker](#) for colour testing
- [Hemingway Editor](#) or similar for readability hints
- [Grammarly](#) for clarity and consistency checks.

Strong, readable content is one of the fastest ways to raise accessibility and conversion together.

Are your images & media accessible?

Images, video, and audio are powerful but can create barriers if they are not described or captioned.

Images

- Provide meaningful alt text for informative images. Describe purpose rather than pixels, for example Product photo of a black waterproof rucksack with roll top closure.
- Leave alt text empty for purely decorative images so screen readers skip them.
- Avoid text baked into images. Use real text in the page so it scales, reflows, and is read out correctly.

Video and audio

- Provide captions for spoken content. Add a transcript so people can search and skim. Include descriptions of essential visual information.
- Provide controls that are easy to reach and operate with a keyboard. Ensure the player shows focus and can be paused and adjusted without a mouse.
- Autoplay creates problems for many users. If you must use it, keep it muted and provide an obvious pause control.

Responsiveness and device testing

- Test on a small phone, a large phone, a tablet, and a laptop. Rotate between portrait and landscape. Content should reflow without hiding controls or overlapping text.
- Use the browser's device toolbar to preview common sizes. Validate that mobile menus are easy to tap and dismiss.

Helpful tools:

- [WAVE](#) to find missing or empty alt attributes.
- [YouTube Studio](#) or a captioning service to create and edit captions.
- [Amara](#) for collaborative subtitling and transcripts.

Accessible media ensures your message lands for people who use screen readers, captions, or transcripts, and it improves discoverability in search.

Assessing your links & buttons

Clear, descriptive, and operable controls are central to an accessible experience.

Link and button text

- Use text that explains the destination or action, for example [Download the brochure](#) or [View accessibility policy](#). Avoid vague phrases such as [Click here](#).
- When several links appear together, each should make sense on its own. Screen readers can present a list of links without surrounding context.

Appearance and feedback

- Links must be visually distinct from regular text. Underlines are reliable and widely understood.
- Buttons should look like interactive controls with shape, border, or elevation.
- Provide visible focus. When tabbing through a page, the active element should be obvious. A prominent focus style supports keyboard users and people with attention or vision differences.

Size and spacing

- Targets should be large enough for touch input. WCAG 2.2 includes guidance on target size and spacing that reduces accidental activation. Provide comfortable padding for mobile users.

Keyboard and screen reader tests

- Tab through every page section. You should be able to move to a control, activate it with Enter or Space, and return without traps.
- Use a screen reader such as [NVDA](#) or [VoiceOver](#) to listen for confusing or duplicated labels.

Checks and tools:

- [Axe DevTools](#) or WAVE for contrast and label issues.
- Manual keyboard testing for focus order and operability.

Stronger labels, obvious affordances, and consistent focus styles improve both accessibility and conversion.

Making sure forms are accessible

Forms are often the point where users convert, which makes accessibility here especially valuable.

Labels and instructions

- Every input needs a visible label that is programmatically associated with the field. Placeholder text is not a label. Keep labels short and plain, for example Email address.
- Provide concise help text where needed. Place it near the field so users do not miss it.

Errors and validation

- Explain what went wrong in plain language and how to fix it. Identify the specific field. Do not rely on colour alone for error states. Include an icon or text.
- Keep input formats flexible. Accept common variations for phone numbers and postcodes. Use input masks carefully and never block pasting into fields like credit card numbers.

Keyboard and focus management

- The tab order should follow the visual order. When errors occur, move focus to an error summary and provide links that jump to each field.
- Ensure checkboxes, radio groups, and custom controls are operable with keyboard only.

CAPTCHA and alternatives

- Offer alternatives that do not depend on complex image recognition. Consider logical questions or email verification. Provide an audio option if you must use a traditional CAPTCHA.

Testing tools:

- WAVE for label associations and error identification.
- Screen reader testing to confirm that labels, errors, and hints are announced in a useful order.

Accessible forms remove friction at the moment that matters and increase successful submissions.

Checking your site's structure & code

Good structure allows assistive technologies to parse content, announce it correctly, and let users move efficiently.

Headings and landmarks

- Use a single H1 per page, followed by H2 and H3 to reflect content structure. Do not choose headings only for size. Style headings with CSS while keeping the logical outline intact.
- Use semantic landmarks such as header, nav, main, aside, and footer. These help screen reader users jump to major regions.

Semantic controls

- Use real buttons for actions that change the page. Reserve links for navigation. Avoid clickable divs that lack semantics.
- Provide informative labels and accessible names. For icons, include an accessible name that matches the visible label.

ARIA used with care

- Prefer native HTML wherever possible. Add ARIA only when semantics are missing. Incorrect ARIA can reduce accessibility rather than improve it.

Bypass blocks and focus order

- Provide a visible Skip to main content link near the top of pages so keyboard users can bypass repeated navigation.

Validation and tests:

- [HTML validator](#) for structural issues.
- WAVE and [Axe](#) for heading order, landmark roles, and name label description checks.
- Tab through pages to confirm sensible focus order.

A sound structure improves accessibility, search indexing, and maintainability in one effort.

Scan your website for issues

Manual checks give context and confidence. Automation adds breadth and speed. The 80five Accessibility Scan brings both together so you can act quickly.

What you receive with the free scan

- A clear PDF report for your home page that lists each issue, why it matters for real users, and practical steps to fix it.
- A count of occurrences so you can prioritise high-impact fixes first.
- Pointers to useful tools and references that support your team.

Upgrade to a full site scan

- We can crawl your website and produce a consolidated report across many pages. You will see patterns that are easy to miss on a single page, such as repeated form errors or low contrast in a component library.
- The report can be paired with a remediation plan, estimates, and a roadmap that fits your release cycle.

How to get started

[Click here for a free scan](#)

Find out if your website
accessible for **everyone?**

Use this guide to make immediate improvements, then let the scan confirm progress and reveal the remaining gaps. Together they provide a practical path to WCAG 2.2 AA alignment and a better experience for every visitor.

Want to get in touch?

If you want to find out more about 80five and how we can help you create an unforgettable website for your business, you can find out more on our website, call us, or drop us an email.



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